Container Logistics Operations — OLIU (Kigali) · JIVAH (Dar es Salaam)

Issues Identification & Solution Outline

Prepared for: The Business Owner / CEO

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Status: Draft for discussion

What changed since version 1. The thirteen issues and the direction are unchanged. Everything marked NEW was worked out while building the clickable mockup and was not yet written down here: the two-company (two books) structure, the two-trail blind reconciliation control, the six roles, the transport & journey module, beneficiary protection, general ledger and bank matching, notifications, configuration and one-time data import, the seven system-wide build rules, and the open decisions that still need the owner's answer (section 8).

1. Purpose

This document records the operational and financial problems identified in the container shipping business across its two companies, and outlines the features a centralized system needs in order to resolve them. It is written so that the owner can confirm the problems are correctly understood before any solution is designed or procured. A clickable mockup of the proposed system now exists; section 4 onward describes what it contains.

2. Summary

The business currently has no single place where bookings, container movements, payments and expenses are recorded. As a result, the owner cannot answer three basic questions at any given moment: how much has been spent on a container, how much was actually earned from it, and how the business as a whole is performing. This creates direct financial leakage (duplicate payments, unmanaged facilitation payments, cargo left behind) and indirect risk (funds handled by staff without oversight, delayed decisions).

NEW The "two offices" are two separate companies with separate books: **OLIU** in Kigali (Rwanda), which bills the client, and **JIVAH** in Dar es Salaam (Tanzania), which carries the Tanzania-side cost. A container passes from one to the other when it clears Rusumo. There is no inter-company debt between them, and the system must not invent one.

Theme	Issues	Main consequence
A. Cost and profitability per container	1 – 3	Profit per shipment is unknown; facilitation payments are uncontrolled
B. Booking and payment control	4 – 6	Cargo left behind, duplicate payments, cash exposure
C. Visibility, documents and reporting	7 – 10	No real-time status; documents scattered; owner decides late or blind
D. Two-company finance management	11 – 13	Total business cost and per-company performance unknown

3. Issues Identified

A. Cost and profitability per container

1. **No end-to-end cost tracking per container.** There is no way to see everything spent on a single container from booking to delivery, including all official charges (shipping line, port, clearing, transport) and informal costs such as facilitation payments.
2. **No visibility of actual profit per container.** Because costs, including post-delivery payments and last-minute changes, are not captured against the container, the owner cannot tell how much was truly earned once a shipment is delivered.
3. **Facilitation payments are unmanaged.** Payments made to expedite clearance, handling or delivery are made ad hoc by staff, are not recorded against the container, and have no approval, limit or reconciliation. The owner cannot see how much is being paid, by whom, or whether the amounts are justified. These payments also carry legal and compliance risk, so at minimum each one should be logged with amount, purpose, payer and approver, and the owner may wish to set a policy on them.

B. Booking and payment control (revenue leakage risk)

4. **Cargo left behind is not tracked.** When 12 containers are booked but only 10 are loaded, the 2 left behind are not systematically followed up. This causes delayed deliveries, rebooking or storage costs, customer complaints and confusion over which cargo has actually moved. It is also one of the causes of duplicate shipping payments when the remaining containers are rebooked and paid for again.
5. **Duplicate shipping payments.** The same shipment is sometimes paid for twice because there is no single record of what has already been paid, to whom and for which container.
6. **Funds at risk in staff hands.** Payments and cash handled by staff are not visible to the owner in real time, creating exposure to errors or misuse without his knowledge.

C. Visibility, documents and reporting

7. **No centralized platform for operations.** Bookings, shipping, clearing, delivery and payments are handled in separate places (paper, spreadsheets, phone messages), so there is no single source of truth and information depends on individual staff members.
8. **No real-time view of container status.** The owner cannot see at any moment where each container is or what stage it has reached (booked, loaded, in transit, at port, cleared, delivered).
9. **No automated business performance reports.** The head of the company has no timely report on how the business is doing, what money is owed or due, and which actions and approvals are pending. Decisions are therefore delayed or made without full information.
10. **No tracking of supporting documents per container.** Bills of lading, packing lists, commercial invoices, customs declarations, release orders, delivery notes and payment receipts are kept in emails, phones or paper files rather than attached to the container they belong to. Documents are hard to find when needed for clearing, customer queries or disputes, can be lost when a staff member leaves, and there is no way to confirm that a container's paperwork is complete before it moves to the next stage.

D. Two-company finance and expense management

11. **No separation of spending between the two companies.** Costs, invoices and pending payments cannot be attributed to a specific company, so the performance of each cannot be compared or controlled.
12. **Pending invoices are not tracked.** There is no consolidated list of unpaid supplier invoices or outstanding customer receivables, so cash flow cannot be predicted.

13. **No central record of overhead expenses.** Rent, payroll, utilities and other running costs across both companies are not recorded in one place, so the total cost of running the business is unknown and cannot be set against shipment income.

4. Solution Outline

The issues above point to one root cause: the absence of a single system of record. The recommended direction is a centralized, web-based operations and finance platform, accessible from both companies and from the owner's phone, built around the container as the central unit. The table below maps each module to the issues it resolves; the mockup implements every module listed.

Module	What it does	Resolves
Container & booking register	One record per container from booking to delivery: customer, shipping line, booking number, vessel, POL/POD, seal, commodity, status, dates. Booked vs loaded is reconciled per shipment; unloaded containers are flagged automatically as **Left behind** and moved to a sister booking number. NEW Container numbers are check-digit verified (ISO 6346); a second entry of the same number is blocked and sent to the MD. Release is signed off once per booking, never per box. Clearing Rusumo flips the responsible company OLIU → JIVAH.	4, 7, 8
Transport & journey NEW	A transport leg is one hire — one truck, one company, one agreed cost, the driver's contact — with a daily position update. Journey stages (Magerwa → Rusumo → ICD → port → ship) are structured fields, not free text. A replacement truck after a breakdown leaves at once; only its *record* waits for the MD.	8
Container cost ledger	Every cost is a line on a container: freight, port, clearing, transport, storage, facilitation and other charges — with beneficiary, currency and the exchange rate of its own date, stored forever. A shared bill across N boxes is split by the system into N lines. Total cost and margin per container are computed, never typed. NEW **Close to Finance** is an explicit step: it freezes the operations cost trail, fixes the P&L month to the month of closing, and opens the client invoice — so a container appears in exactly one month's P&L.	1, 2, 5
Payments & approvals	All outgoing payments recorded with payee, purpose, container and company, in fixed states: requested, approved, rejected, paid. Duplicate-payment check on the same container, category and payee — a repeat is blocked and sent to the MD queue, never silently saved. Approval workflow above a threshold set by the owner; NEW approvals above the threshold are confirmed with a one-time code to the *department* mailbox (MFA), not a personal inbox.	3, 5, 6
Facilitation payment log	Dedicated, restricted log: amount, purpose, container(s), paid by, approved by, date. Saved on the phone in three taps, offline-capable; details can be completed later. Monthly cap per company: at 80% the owner is emailed, at 100% every further tip is flagged to the MD — saving is never refused. NEW A per-tip ceiling flags any single large tip at once. The approver is derived by rule (Finance match or MD ruling), not chosen by the payer. The policy is a configuration table the owner edits, not code.	3, 6
Two-trail reconciliation NEW	**The control the whole system rests on.** Operations records what a cost was at the point of payment; the Finance Officer later records the same cost from the physical invoice *without seeing the operations figure*. The system compares the two trails per container. A match is silent; a mismatch, a repeat payment, a second container number or a replacement leg lands in the MD queue with both figures, both authors and both timestamps. Nothing is auto-corrected; the MD's ruling is a third, append-only record. Only the MD sees both trails.	3, 5, 6

Container document file	Every supporting document (bill of lading, packing list, invoice, customs declaration, release order, delivery note, receipts — ten papers) is uploaded and attached to its container. A required-per-stage list shows which documents are missing before the box moves on; a completeness report lists every gap.	7, 10
Invoicing & receivables	Customer invoices issued from the container record by OLIU; payment status tracked; overdue list per company. NEW Every invoice is either *we pay* (AP) or *client pays* (AR) — never mixed on one document. An AR invoice may bundle several containers; each container's revenue still resolves back to it, net of credit notes. The client invoice can only be raised once the container is closed and all own costs are covered. Overdue reminders escalate at 7, 30 and 45 days.	2, 12
Beneficiary register NEW	One record per payee with bank details. A bank account number can never be changed by one person alone: a second approval with a one-time code to the department mailbox is required, and old and new numbers stay in the audit trail forever.	5, 6
Expenses & payroll (per company)	Rent, salaries, utilities and other overheads recorded and tagged to a company, with monthly budget comparison. NEW Payroll is a payment like any other: one approval item per company, paid only after MD approval; payslips per employee; statutory lines (RSSB, PAYE) computed from configured rates with reminders to declare. Recurring bills remind before they fall due.	11, 13
General ledger & bank statement NEW	Nobody posts raw journals: every entry is generated by a document (invoice, approved payment, expense, payroll run); adjustments are their own document type and need MD approval. When a month is locked its journals freeze. Bank statement lines are imported or typed and matched to a payment order or received invoice; unmatched lines stay visible — accounting ends at the bank statement, not at "marked paid".	6, 12, 13
Owner dashboard & reports	Real-time view: containers by status, cash in/out, profit per container, per-company P&L, pending approvals. Automatic daily summary at 07:00 and a weekly one on Monday, sent to the owner by email and WhatsApp — the same numbers as the dashboard, no login needed. NEW The MD alone sees a **Group view** block: both books side by side, year to date, with a downloadable board pack. It is a display sum of two books, not a consolidation. Every figure is a query on the same records; no report has its own stored totals.	6, 8, 9, 11
Notifications NEW	Every status that today travels by phone call or WhatsApp becomes a notification: approval requested, container left behind, tip cap reached, invoice overdue, document missing. Reminders escalate on their own (an unapproved payment reminds daily). Each user chooses in-app, email or WhatsApp per type.	6, 8, 9
Users, roles & audit trail	Each of the twelve staff has an individual login and one of six roles (section 5); shared accounts are impossible; the one-time sign-in code goes to the department mailbox. Roles set *visibility*, not just permission — a screen a role cannot use is not shown. Every create, change, approval, flag, ruling, login and export is recorded with user, time and before/after values; nothing is edited or deleted by anyone, including the MD; records are kept at least five years for RRA/TRA and external audit.	6, 7

Configuration & data import NEW	Owner-editable lists, not code: payment approval threshold, facilitation policy (per-tip ceiling, monthly cap per company, reasons), cost categories, journey stages, reconciliation tolerance, statutory rates. One-time import of the current spreadsheets (FINANCE MASTER XL 2026, SHIPMENT REPORT 2026, the expense register, the beneficiary list) with a reconciliation report the owner signs off before go-live — the business never starts from zero.	7
Ask the MIS NEW (consultant's suggestion)	Plain-language questions by role — "what did we earn on Space Mining this month?" — answered from the same records as the screens. A convenience layer, never a second source of truth. Proposed by the consultant, not requested by the owner; can be dropped without affecting anything else.	9

5. Roles — who does what NEW

Six roles only. The MD is the only role with no company to protect and the only one who sees both companies' books and both cost trails. The Finance Officer never sees the operations money trail while entering.

Role	Sees and does	May not
Managing Director (owner)	Everything. Approves payments, rules on reconciliation flags and the MD queue, approves beneficiary changes, manages users, sees Group view and receives the daily summary.	Edit or delete history — the MD's rulings are records like everyone else's.
Operations Manager (one per company)	Bookings, containers, container record and costs, transport, release, journey; approves payment requests within threshold; closes containers to Finance; invoices, beneficiaries, office expenses, reports.	Pay; see the Finance trail; change bank accounts alone; see the other company.
Finance Officer (one per company)	Pays approved orders and enters the cost *blind* from the paper invoice; invoices (AP/AR), bank statement matching, payroll, general ledger, expenses, reports.	See the operations figure while entering; approve; create bookings or costs on the operations side.
Transport Coordinator	Transport legs, daily truck position, journey stages, release, facilitation entries, container costs.	Approve or pay; see finance screens.
Field Officer	Three-tap facilitation entry on the phone, container status lookup, notifications.	Anything else — the screen list is deliberately short.
Reporting Officer	Read-only across both companies: dashboard, containers, container P&L, invoices, general ledger, reports, audit trail.	Create, edit, approve or pay anything.

6. Rules the system must enforce NEW

1. **The container is the unit.** Costs, documents, status, P&L and flags all hang off Booking № + Container №. Nothing money-related exists without a container (office expenses and payroll are the only exceptions).
2. **Two trails, one compare.** Operations and Finance write independently; Finance cannot see the operations figure while entering. The comparison runs per container and produces flags — it never edits either side.
3. **Totals are queries, never stored.** Container, booking, month and company totals are computed from lines at read time, so they cannot drift.

4. **Append-only.** No record is edited or deleted after save. Corrections, rulings and reopenings are new records that point at the old one. The audit trail is the same data, read backwards.
5. **Roles set visibility, not just permission.** A screen a role cannot use is not shown to it; a blocked attempt is logged.
6. **Two books, no inter-company debt.** OLIU and JIVAH are separate companies in the data model. There is no "JIVAH owes OLIU" account. OLIU bills the client; JIVAH holds the Tanzania-side cost. Group view is a side-by-side display, not a consolidation.
7. **Every approval above threshold is confirmed by a one-time code** to the department mailbox, and beneficiary account changes need two people.

7. Key reports for the owner

All seven exist in the mockup as saved queries on the same records — nothing in them is typed in.

- **Profit per container:** cost, revenue and margin for each shipment, updated as costs are posted; reported in the month the container was closed.
- **Container status board:** booked, loaded, left behind, in transit, at port, cleared, delivered — with booked vs loaded per shipment.
- **Cash-out report:** all payments made this week/month by company, payee and purpose, with facilitation payments shown separately.
- **Pending invoices:** unpaid supplier invoices (aged payables) and unpaid customer invoices (aged receivables), by age — never mixed.
- **Document completeness:** containers with missing or incomplete paperwork at their current stage.
- **Office comparison:** income, direct costs and overheads for each company side by side, against budget, with facilitation and bank charges shown as "of which" lines.
- **Pending actions:** payments awaiting approval, containers left behind, overdue invoices, reconciliation flags, approaching deadlines.

NEW In addition: the **07:00 daily summary** (email + WhatsApp), the **Monday weekly summary**, the **Group board pack** (PDF, MD only), the **income statement** per company and combined, and the **audit trail** as a filterable report.

8. Decisions still open for the owner NEW

#	Question	Why it matters
1	**Blind entry on the JIVAH side.** In Tanzania the accountant has also been recording operations. If one person writes both trails, the compare has nothing independent to compare. Who writes the operations trail in Dar es Salaam?	The two-trail control is settled for Rwanda only.
2	**Reconciliation tolerance.** Is 9,000 RWF on a 1.9 M RWF leg a real flag or rounding — exact match, or a small percentage band for currency drift only?	Sets how many flags reach the MD each week.
3	**Who works the reconciliation screen day to day** — the MD, or a trusted delegate?	Depends on the flag volume from question 2.
4	**Who holds the phone in the field** — a dispatcher taking calls at a desk, or someone travelling with the cargo?	Decides whether offline-first tip entry is essential or optional.

5	**Payment approval threshold and facilitation policy figures** (per-tip ceiling, monthly cap per company). Placeholder values are in the mockup.	Needed before the approval and cap rules can be switched on.
6	**Group view placement** — bottom of the MD's dashboard (as built) or at the top; and which morning alerts matter most.	Front-page layout for the owner.
7	**Ask the MIS** — keep, or drop the consultant's suggestion.	No dependency; scope and cost only.

9. Suggested next steps

- Owner confirms or corrects the thirteen issues above and ranks the top three by priority.
- Owner walks through the clickable mockup in each of the six roles and answers the seven open decisions in section 8.
- Walk through the current process at each company to document who records what, and where, today — in particular the Dar es Salaam accountant's dual role.
- Agree the payment approval threshold and the facilitation policy figures; enter them in Configuration.
- Prepare a functional requirements specification from the mockup's "How it must be built" rules and evaluate build vs. off-the-shelf options.
- Import and reconcile the current spreadsheets; owner signs off the reconciliation report.
- Pilot with one company and a limited set of containers before full rollout.